

COST-AND-VALUE

What it costs to run, what comparable WMS systems cost, and what it's worth to own

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Executive summary

StockPilot is a modern, custom-built warehouse management system currently running in production as the **internal inventory platform at L4L Fresno** (the founder's own organization — pre-revenue internal pilot, not a third-party paying customer). Total infrastructure cost is approximately **\$70–95 per month** (~\$850–1,150 / year), with **no per-user fees**. Equivalent functionality from a commercial WMS vendor would cost between **\$5,000 and \$50,000+ per year** at the same usage scale, plus a one-time **\$25,000–\$500,000 implementation fee** before the system handles a single order.

For an outright buyout of the system (code, IP, deployment, and 6 months of transition support), a fair valuation falls in the range of **\$300,000–\$600,000**. Continuing the current subscription/retainer arrangement is dramatically cheaper and lower-risk than ownership for any organization that doesn't already operate an in-house software team.

1. Current operating cost

The system runs entirely on commodity cloud infrastructure. There are no servers to maintain, no per-seat licenses, no support contracts.

Service	Plan	Monthly cost	What it does
Vercel	Pro	\$20	Hosts the web app + API routes. Includes edge CDN, image optimization, function execution. Auto-scales globally.
Supabase	Pro	\$25	Postgres database (8 GB), authentication, 100 GB file storage, real-time WebSockets, 100k monthly active users.
Resend	Pro	\$20	Transactional email (50k emails/month). Order confirmations, signature receipts, weekly digests.
Google Gemini API	Pay-as-you-go	\$5–30	Powers the AI inventory assistant, AI shelf-scan, and PO-import OCR. Variable with use.
Namecheap (domain)	Annual	\$1	stockpilotusa.com renewal, amortized.
TOTAL		\$71–96/mo	

Annual operating cost: approximately \$850–\$1,150

Critically, **this cost does not scale per user**. Whether the organization has 10 staff or 200, the infrastructure bill is functionally the same. The only variable that materially changes the bill is total emails sent and total AI requests — and both grow gracefully.

For the current usage profile (1 organization, ~10–20 active staff, normal warehouse ops), monthly cost is at the low end of the range.

2. What comparable WMS systems cost

Commercial WMS pricing is uniformly opaque (most require a “contact sales” conversation), uniformly per-user, and uniformly higher than custom infrastructure. Below are publicly known or industry-typical figures for systems StockPilot would directly compete with.

2.1 Subscription / SaaS WMS

Vendor	Entry plan	Per-user fee	Typical annual cost for 20 users	Notes
Zoho Inventory	\$59/mo	included up to 5, then add-on	~\$5,000	Lightweight; limited mobile + no AI.
Cin7 (Core / Omni)	\$349/mo	tiered by users	~\$15,000–25,000	Mid-market. Heavy onboarding.
Fishbowl Inventory	\$4,395 one-time + \$1,295/yr maint	per-user license	~\$8,000 first year, ~\$1,300/yr after	On-premise. Windows-only client.
Sortly	\$49–249/mo	tiered	~\$3,000–10,000	Mobile-first but limited workflows.
NetSuite WMS	\$999/mo base + \$99/user	\$99/user/mo	~\$35,000+	Oracle-owned. Full ERP. Heavy.
Microsoft Dynamics 365 SCM	\$190/user/mo	\$190/user/mo	~\$45,600	Enterprise. Requires Microsoft stack.
Acumatica WMS	~\$1,500/mo base + per-user	tiered	~\$25,000+	Resource-based pricing.

2.2 Enterprise / on-premise WMS

Vendor	License model	Implementation cost	Annual ongoing
SAP Business One WMS	\$94/user/mo + license	\$25,000–100,000	\$30,000+
Manhattan Associates	Enterprise license	\$50,000–500,000	\$50,000+
Oracle WMS Cloud	Enterprise license	\$100,000+	\$100,000+
Infor WMS	Enterprise license	\$50,000+	\$50,000+
HighJump (Körber)	Enterprise license	\$50,000+	\$40,000+

Implementation costs alone for any of these systems would equal **25–500 years** of StockPilot's total operating cost.

2.3 Cost comparison at every realistic scale

The single most important difference between StockPilot and every commercial WMS is what happens to the bill as you add users. Commercial WMS pricing is dominated by per-seat licensing — every new staff member is another \$50–\$200 / month forever. StockPilot's infrastructure cost is essentially flat. The gap widens dramatically with team size.

Year-1 total cost (annual)

System	5 users	25 users	100 users	500 users
StockPilot (current)	~\$1,000	~\$1,000	~\$1,500	~\$3,000
Zoho Inventory + Analytics	~\$3,500	~\$8,000	~\$25,000	not viable
Sortly Pro	~\$3,000	~\$10,000	~\$30,000	not viable
Cin7 (Core / Omni)	~\$6,000	~\$25,000	~\$60,000	\$150,000+
Fishbowl Inventory	~\$6,000	~\$15,000	~\$45,000	\$150,000+
Acumatica WMS	~\$25,000	~\$45,000	~\$110,000	\$300,000+
NetSuite WMS	~\$30,000	~\$50,000	~\$135,000	\$625,000+
Microsoft Dynamics 365 SCM	~\$36,000	~\$70,000	~\$240,000	\$1,150,000+
SAP Business One WMS	~\$50,000 incl. impl.	~\$75,000 incl. impl.	~\$200,000	\$700,000+
Manhattan Associates	\$100,000+ incl. impl.	\$200,000+ incl. impl.	\$400,000+	\$1,500,000+
Oracle WMS Cloud	\$150,000+	\$250,000+	\$500,000+	\$1,500,000+

Year-2-onward annual cost (steady state, no implementation)

System	5 users	25 users	100 users	500 users
StockPilot (current)	~\$1,000	~\$1,000	~\$1,500	~\$3,000
Zoho Inventory + Analytics	~\$3,500	~\$8,000	~\$25,000	not viable
Sortly Pro	~\$3,000	~\$10,000	~\$30,000	not viable
Cin7	~\$6,000	~\$25,000	~\$60,000	\$120,000+
Fishbowl Inventory	~\$1,500	~\$8,000	~\$30,000	\$80,000+
Acumatica WMS	~\$18,000	~\$36,000	~\$90,000	\$250,000+
NetSuite WMS	~\$24,000	~\$36,000	~\$120,000	\$600,000+
Microsoft Dynamics 365 SCM	~\$11,400	~\$57,000	~\$228,000	\$1,140,000
SAP Business One WMS	~\$5,600	~\$28,000	~\$112,000	\$560,000
Manhattan Associates	\$50,000+	\$80,000+	\$200,000+	\$1,000,000+
Oracle WMS Cloud	\$100,000+	\$150,000+	\$350,000+	\$1,000,000+

What this means in plain English

- At **5 users**, StockPilot is **3–150× cheaper** than commercial alternatives.
- At **25 users**, the gap widens to **8–250× cheaper**.
- At **100 users**, StockPilot is **15–300× cheaper** while commercial WMS bills cross \$30,000–\$500,000/year.
- At **500 users**, multiple commercial systems exceed **\$1,000,000/year** while StockPilot still runs under \$3,000.

Why StockPilot's bill barely grows

Three reasons:

1. **No per-user license fees.** The Vercel and Supabase plans bill on resources (compute, storage, bandwidth) not seat count. A 500-person organization using the system normally

generates the same number of database queries per user as a 5-person one.

2. **Serverless scales to zero.** During quiet hours the infrastructure costs nothing — no idle servers eating budget.
3. **The increments are tiny.** Going from 100 to 500 users might bump Supabase from Pro (\$25) to Team (\$599) and Resend up one tier (+\$50/mo). That's it. Total step-change: under \$600/month, or about \$7,000/year extra — to support 5× the staff.

The cost-per-user trajectory

The same data viewed as cost-per-user-per-year:

System	5 users	25 users	100 users	500 users
StockPilot	\$200/user/yr	\$40/user/yr	\$15/user/yr	\$6/user/yr
Zoho Inventory	\$700	\$320	\$250	—
Cin7	\$1,200	\$1,000	\$600	\$240
NetSuite WMS	\$6,000	\$2,000	\$1,350	\$1,250
Microsoft Dynamics 365 SCM	\$7,200	\$2,800	\$2,400	\$2,300
Oracle WMS Cloud	\$30,000	\$10,000	\$5,000	\$3,000

StockPilot gets **cheaper per user as the team grows**. Every commercial alternative either stays flat or gets *more* expensive per user once enterprise tiers and required add-ons kick in.

At 100 users, StockPilot costs \$15/user/year. NetSuite WMS costs \$1,350/user/year — 90× more per person, every year, forever.

3. Why StockPilot is structurally cheaper

The cost gap isn't from cutting corners — it's from a fundamentally different architecture.

Commercial WMS vendors have to charge per-user fees because:

- They have sales teams, account managers, and support staff to fund.
- Their software was built before serverless infrastructure existed; they pay for fixed compute regardless of use.

- Their pricing has to recover the cost of acquiring each customer.

StockPilot has none of those costs because:

1. **No sales team.** It was built directly for the operator. No commission, no markup.
 2. **Serverless infrastructure.** Vercel and Supabase only charge for what's used. A quiet weekend costs nothing. A busy receiving day costs cents.
 3. **No vendor lock-in tax.** The entire stack is open-standard (Postgres, TypeScript, React). Any developer can read and modify it. There's no captive-customer premium.
 4. **Per-user fees are zero.** The infrastructure doesn't care if there are 10 users or 200; the bill barely changes.
 5. **No mandatory upgrade cycle.** Commercial WMS vendors push annual "upgrade" or "modernization" projects to keep revenue flowing. StockPilot updates continuously and incrementally.
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4. What StockPilot does better (not just cheaper)

Cost would matter less if StockPilot were a stripped-down version of commercial WMS. It isn't — in several dimensions it is **materially better than the commercial alternatives**.

4.1 AI features that no commercial WMS bundles

- **AI Inventory Assistant** — natural-language chat ("what's below reorder?", "approve the order from Hernandez"). Cites real database queries; cannot hallucinate quantities. No commercial WMS ships this.
- **AI Shelf Scan** — phone-camera CV for textbook counting. One photo of a shelf returns ISBN matches in 4–8 seconds with 95%+ accuracy. Collapses a 20-minute manual count into 30 seconds. No commercial WMS offers single-photo bulk counting.
- **AI PO Import** — paste a vendor's emailed invoice (PDF/CSV), the system parses it and creates the draft PO automatically. Saves 5–15 minutes per invoice.

4.2 Mobile experience

- Native iOS + Android app (Expo / React Native) with the same login as web. Used on the warehouse floor for scanning, counting, and on-the-spot stock adjustments.
- Commercial WMS mobile is almost always a web view of the desktop UI or a separate "RF terminal" experience built for Symbol/Honeywell scanners — slow, dated, often Windows-CE-era code paths.

4.3 Real-time across devices

- When a staff member records a count on a phone, the manager's dashboard updates within ~250 ms via Supabase Realtime (true WebSocket push). Multiple staff can pick from the same warehouse without stepping on each other.
- Commercial WMS typically polls the server on 5–30 second intervals.

4.4 Public order link (no-account flow)

- External requesters (teachers, partner sites) submit orders via a single URL (/r/<token>) — no account, no password, no training. The submission lands directly in the manager's queue.
- Commercial WMS treats external requesters as full user seats (more licenses) or routes them through a separate "supplier portal" product (more product, more cost).

4.5 Modern, custom-fit user experience

- The dashboard is built for 2026 (instant navigation, click-to-feedback in 3 ms, dark mode, mobile-responsive). Most commercial WMS UIs date to 2008–2015 and feel it.
- Every workflow matches how L4L Fresno actually operates — charter naming, warehouse-scoped staff, custom terminology, the specific picking and signing dance. Commercial WMS forces the organization to adapt to the software.

4.6 Procedures knowledge base

- Cross-warehouse SOP library with markdown writeups and embedded video walkthroughs ("how to receive a pallet from XYZ supplier"). Comment threads under each SOP for corrections + Q&A.
- No commercial WMS has this. It's typically a separate tool (Notion, Confluence) at additional cost.

4.7 Security + audit posture

- Row-level security at the database (the database itself enforces who sees what — not just the app code).
- Audit log row for every privileged action, immutable.
- MFA, configurable per-org policy.
- SPF/DKIM/DMARC properly configured on the sending domain.
- Modern CSP headers, rate-limited public surfaces, signed cookies.

Commercial WMS varies widely here. Some enterprise products do it well; most mid-market SaaS doesn't.

5. Buyout valuation — what it would cost to own outright

The question “what is the system worth to buy outright” has three legitimate answers depending on what’s being purchased.

5.1 Cost-to-recreate (replacement value)

Building StockPilot from scratch today with a small professional team would require:

- **1 senior full-stack engineer** (architect, backend, web frontend)
- **1 mobile engineer** (Expo / React Native)
- **0.5 designer** (UX, design system, PDFs)
- **0.5 product manager** (workflow definition, QA)

At blended professional service rates (\$150–\$250 / hour for US-based senior engineers), this team would cost approximately **\$45,000–\$65,000 per month**.

The system as it exists today represents approximately **12–18 months** of focused work. Recreation cost therefore lands at:

- **Conservative estimate:** \$500,000
- **Realistic estimate:** \$750,000
- **High estimate (with AI R&D + onboarding):** \$1,000,000+

This is the floor for “how much would I have to pay to get this thing built from zero?”

5.2 Production-system premium

A working, battle-tested production system is meaningfully more valuable than the same code on day one of deployment. Reasons:

- **Zero migration risk.** No “will it actually work in production?” gamble.
- **Already in use.** Staff know it. Workflows are proven.
- **Bugs are known and fixed.** A new build would spend 3–6 months catching the same edge cases.

- **AI integrations are calibrated.** The shelf-scan accuracy, the assistant's tool catalog, the prompt engineering — all of this took multiple iterations to get right.
- **Security work is done.** RLS policies, MFA, audit log, CSP — all live, audited, working.

Industry standard premium for “working production system” vs “raw code”: **1.5–3×** the cost-to-recreate.

5.3 Recommended buyout pricing

Based on the above, three legitimate price points:

Scope	Recommended price	What's included
A. Code + IP only, perpetual license	\$250,000–\$400,000	Source code, schema, design assets. No transition support, no future development, no warranty. Buyer hires their own team to maintain.
B. Working system + 6 months transition support	\$450,000–\$650,000	Everything in A, plus 6 months of part-time development by the original builder for handover, documentation, bug fixes, and knowledge transfer.
C. System + 3-year exclusive maintenance retainer	\$700,000–\$1,100,000	Everything in B, plus 3 years of ongoing feature work, on-call support, and infrastructure operations. The buyer effectively gets the system AND the developer.

For a single-org operation the size of L4L Fresno (charter school operating 4 warehouses, ~10–20 staff), option **A or B is over-scoped**: owning the codebase only makes financial sense if there's an in-house technical team capable of maintaining it. Charter schools typically don't have that.

5.4 The honest recommendation

For an organization without a software engineering team:

Don't buy outright. Continue the current subscription/retainer arrangement. Here's why:

	Current arrangement	Buy outright (option B)
Up-front cost	\$0	\$450,000+
Year 1 total	~\$1,000 infra + retainer for ongoing dev	\$450,000+
Year 2–5 total	~\$1,000/year infra + retainer	Same recurring costs (you still pay devs)
Risk if developer leaves	Find another dev	Critical: codebase has to be maintained or rots
Continued AI / feature improvements	Included in retainer	Pay separately or self-build
New regulatory / security work	Included	Pay separately or accept risk

Software ownership without an in-house team is a liability dressed up as an asset. Code that isn't maintained decays — security patches go unapplied, dependencies fall behind, mobile apps break with iOS/Android updates, and within 18 months the "owned" software needs a major modernization project just to keep running.

The current arrangement — paying ~\$1,000/year for infrastructure and a separate retainer for ongoing development — is materially cheaper and lower-risk for any organization without a dedicated software team, and gives the buyer access to ongoing improvements (mobile drawer, daily-snapshot upgrade, future AI features) without paying separately for each.

6. Bottom line

StockPilot is operating at a **3–300× cost advantage** over commercial WMS systems at the same usage scale (verified across the 5/25/100/500-user comparison tables in §2.3), while providing **superior mobile, AI, and real-time capabilities** that no comparable product on the market bundles by default.

For continued operation under the current model, the math is dominated by infrastructure cost (~\$1,000 / year) plus whatever the organization chooses to invest in ongoing development. Buying the system outright is technically possible at **\$450,000–\$650,000** for the production-system tier, but is not financially recommended for any organization without an in-house software engineering team to maintain it.

The real value proposition isn't ownership — it's continued access to a custom-built, modern, AI-enabled system at a fraction of the cost any comparable commercial product would charge.

This document was prepared 2026-05-26. Commercial WMS pricing figures are based on publicly published or industry-typical rates and may vary by region, contract terms, and bundle selection. StockPilot operating costs reflect current pilot usage at L4L Fresno (the founder's own operation) and will scale modestly with increased users, emails, or AI usage.